

# For *la Patria*

POLITICS AND THE ARMED  
FORCES IN LATIN AMERICA

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## 2

### Inventing *la Patria*

#### Wars, *Caudillismo*, and Politics, 1810–1885

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The tyrants of my country have taken it from me, and I now have not even a *patria* for which to sacrifice myself.

—Simón Bolívar

Make me a colonel. I'll do the rest.

—Felipe Santiago Salaverry, Peru, 1835

Just as the development of European nation-states in the centuries after 1492 resulted in part from warmaking and the rise of modern armies, so too in Latin America did new states emerge from independence wars between 1810 and 1826. These were not "nation-states," for no nations existed. They lacked clear territorial demarcation and their peoples did not share a single cultural and historical past—except perhaps the glorious (for *conquistadores*) and painful (for the conquered, the enslaved, and their offspring) legacy of conquest and colonialism. Creole patriotism, the Spanish American elite's growing self-identity and hostility to Spanish rule, usually excluded native peoples and Afro-Americans.<sup>1</sup> There was no cherished *patria*, no post-French Revolution liberal *patria*, only *patrias chicas* to defend against Simón Bolívar and other liberators' dreams of continental unity.<sup>2</sup> Not until the late nineteenth century did the modern configuration of territorial nation-states become firmly imprinted.

Wars, rebellions, and pervasive violence dominated Latin American politics almost to the end of the nineteenth century. Besides killing and immiserating, war challenges the fiscal and administrative capacity of governments, dislocates economies, and destroys infrastructure. It also mobilizes resources, encourages technological innovation, generates new economic opportunities, and changes societies. War alters boundaries—territorial, social, and psychological—and both centralizes and fragments political authority. Sometimes it creates (or consolidates) nations; other times it mutilates or destroys them. It gives soldiers the right to dispose of lives and property, and the opportunity to do so without the right. If war and civil strife become permanent, the habits of war become the habits of society, shaping attitudes and expectations, subverting respect for political principles and civility, and cheapening human life. This was what war did in much of Latin America.

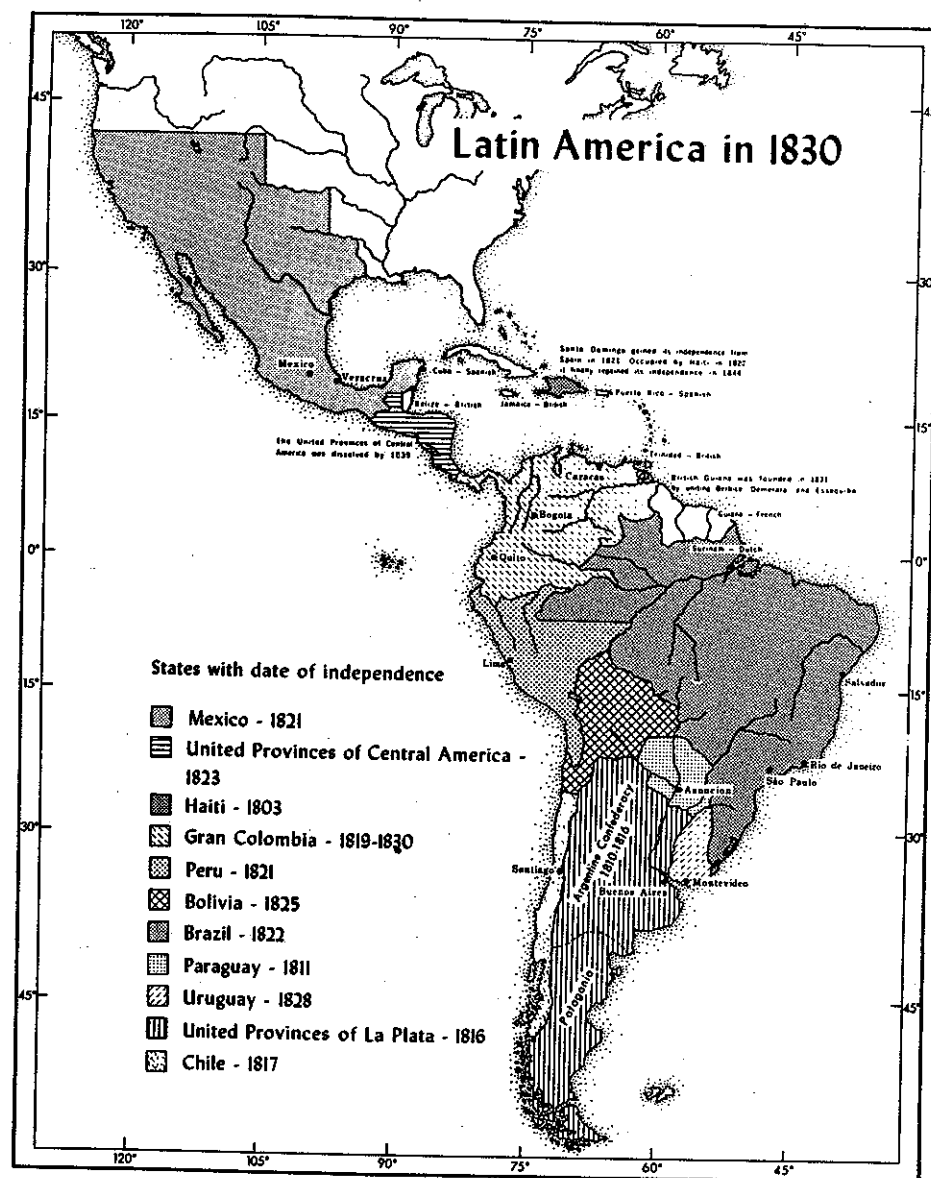
Latin America consisted of ports and poorly connected towns and villages amid vast contested hinterlands. It was a patchwork of local and regional fiefdoms separated by rugged mountains, gigantic river systems, deserts, plains, jungles, and the irregular armies of hundreds of ex-patriot officers, landowners, and political bosses. Personalist, factional, regional, religious, racial, and ideological conflicts made it virtually impossible to consolidate and legitimate governments in the new countries. Such varied conflicts make it even more difficult to generalize regarding nation-building in the region without drawing the ire of historians rightfully concerned with national and regional particularities. Nevertheless, some common patterns emerged.

Reestablishing political order after separation from Spain and Portugal was a monumental challenge made more difficult because of disagreement on boundaries and because of the lack of consensus on basic political principles, on whether the new states should be monarchies or republics, and on whether they should be organized on centralist, federal, or confederal models. Controversies over the Church's role in the independent states exacerbated political conflicts. Spain, France, Italy, and Germany also experienced considerable internal strife and international wars in struggling to create and consolidate nation-states, but three centuries of colonialism, miscegenation, cultural syncretism, and politically imposed racial stratification distinguished nation-building in Spanish America and Brazil from nineteenth-century Europe. Wars against hostile Indians in Mexico, Río de la Plata, and Chile, *criollo* fears of race war, and the lingering slavery issue also temporarily impeded national consolidation and complicated policy debates—as in the United States. These conflicts, worsened by wartime destruction, weak economies, and vulnerability to foreign intervention, contributed to the militarization of Latin American politics. They made “generals,” “colonels,” and garrisons paramount for more than one-half century after independence.

Great variations existed in the character, degree, and duration of post-independence Latin American militarism. In Mexico and to some extent Peru, former royalist military officers dominated post-independence governments. In northern South America and Chile this was less so, although independence war heroes such as José Antonio Páez (Venezuela), Andrés Santa Cruz (Bolivia and Peru), Juan José Flores (Ecuador), and sundry generals and colonels dominated politics almost to midcentury. In Central America, independence came virtually without war, although civil-military *caudillos* created the new nations that fragmented from the failed Central American Federation (1824–1838).

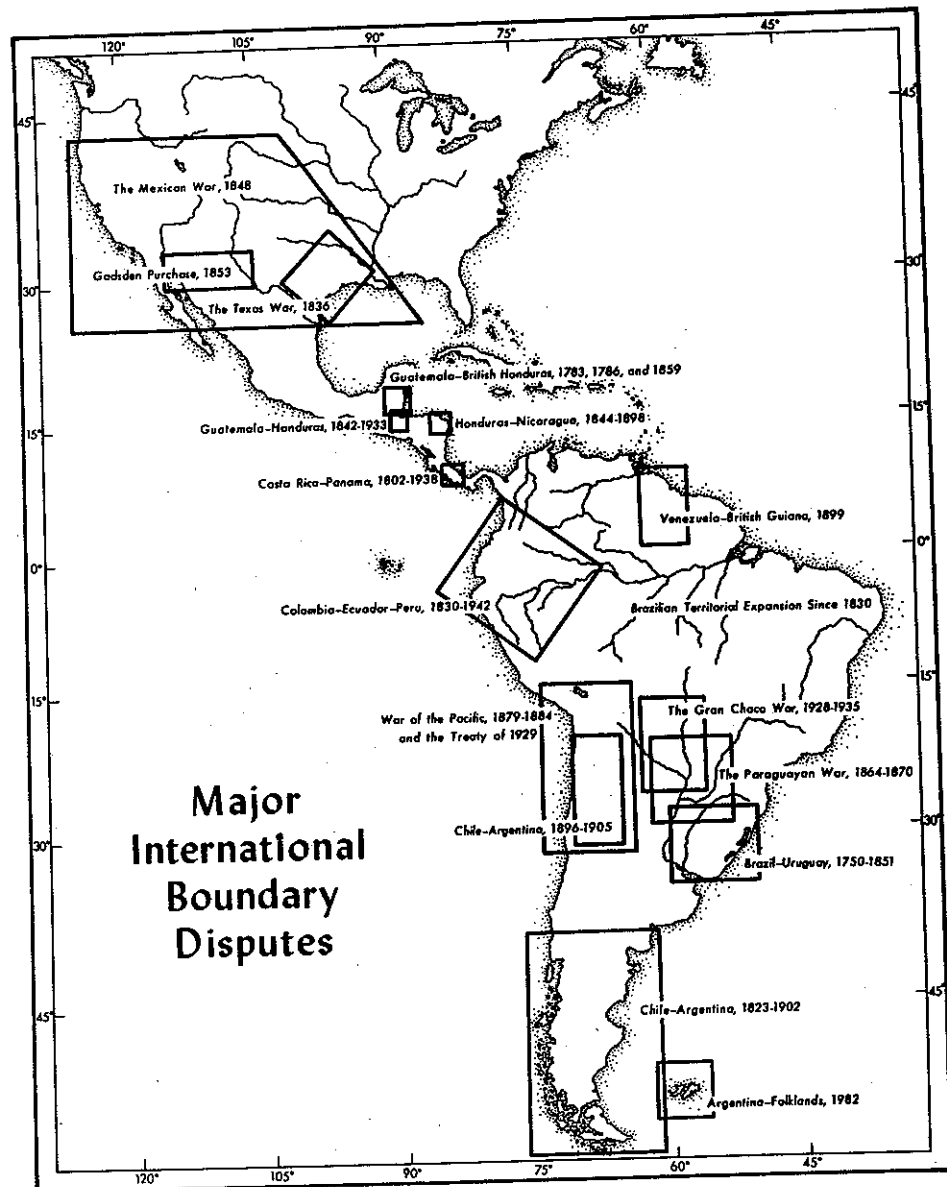
Latin Americans fought wars to determine national boundaries, to create large confederal nations—Central America (1824–1838), Gran Colombia (1821–1830), Peru-Colombia (1828–1830), Río de la Plata (1817–1860), Peru-Bolivia (1836–1841)—and then to carve smaller countries from them. In the case of Uruguay, a new country emerged from war between Brazil and Río de la Plata mediated by England (1825–1828). These were essentially wars of political consolidation (see Table 2–2) that determined both the boundaries of new states and the composition of “national” governments. Wars against European invaders and against other Latin American states further determined territorial boundaries and yielded a small pantheon of military heroes.

Whatever the circumstances, these wars simultaneously involved nation-building, territorial disputes, internal ideological and political conflicts, personalist and factional strife, and naked struggles over political power and government revenues. They were always more complex than pithy retrospective summaries indicate. Commonly, however, the wars sprang from a lack of political consensus and a failure to consolidate new nation-states within the larger Spanish colonial jurisdictions. They were fought by armies of peasants, ranch hands, vagrants, artisans, and workers led mainly by officers without



Map 2-1. Latin America in 1830. From Cathryn L. Lombardi and John V. Lombardi, with Lynn Stoner, *Latin American History, A Teaching Atlas*, published for the Conference on Latin American History by the University of Wisconsin Press, 1983, p. 49. Reprinted by permission of the University of Wisconsin Press

any formal military training. These armies were pre-modern and pre-professional. They lacked officers educated in military academies with common doctrines, strategic and tactical orientation, and career systems. They were not organized under an operational general staff, did virtually no planning for diverse military threats, carried out few military exercises, and were unprepared for sustained combat. Equipped with muskets, bayonets, small arms, knives, machetes, swords, lances, and the occasional artillery pieces, these armies killed and maimed at close range, typically hand to hand, without dis-



Map 2-2. Major International Boundary Disputes. From Cathryn L. Lombardi and John V. Lombardi, with Lynn Stoner, *Latin American History, A Teaching Atlas*, published for the Conference on Latin American History by the University of Wisconsin Press, 1983, p. 52. Reprinted by permission of the University of Wisconsin Press

cipline or practiced maneuvers. They not infrequently finished battles, if they could, with massacres.

Yet these armies fought in the name of *la patria*, and their victories and defeats became part of the martial mythology of the Latin American armed forces. Whatever the immediate "causes" of war, at stake was the meaning of *la patria*, its territory, historical myths, military heroes, and fundamental values. Would *la patria* be liberal or conservative, Catholic or pluralistic, centralist, federal, or confederal? Would the myths eulogize or demonize the Iberian conquest, glorify or despise the native peoples, sanctify hierarchy and racial stratification with pseudo-science or proclaim the virtue of "equality"? Would *la patria* be conceived as an organism, with a brain (government) and a central nervous system, subject to injury, infection, and cancer that would require political cures? Or as a patriarchal family in which miscreant children were disciplined? Or as a homeland (*madre-patria*) that would nurture diversity and tolerate pluralism in the "national family"?

New *patrias* had to be constructed, defended, and governed. Elite and European versions sometimes blended and sometimes collided with regional, local, and peasant objectives and visions of collective identity. Ultimately, "Peru," "Bolivia," "Chile," "Uruguay," "Mexico," and other nations emerged from hundreds of local, regional, and international conflicts in which peasants fought for land, Indian peoples for communal integrity, slaves and former slaves for liberation and opportunity, *caudillos* for wealth and power, and intellectuals for "civilization"—all in the name of some *patria* or other.<sup>3</sup>

At first, *patria* referred to multiple and overlapping territories and identities: "Spanish America," a province, a geographical region, an administrative center, or even a particular hacienda (the extreme version of *patria chica*), not to an abstract nation united by culture, language, or common history. In the Río de la Plata region the term *patria* referred to a person's native province, not to an Argentine, Paraguayan, or Uruguayan nation: "What does the *patria* mean to you? The fatherland for the *correntino* is Corrientes; for the *cordobés*, Córdoba; for the *tucumano*, Tucumán; for the *porteño*, Buenos Aires; for the gaucho, the *pago* [locality] where he was born. Everyone fights for his own corner, and the larger national interests are an 'incomprehensible abstraction.'" <sup>4</sup>

As in most of Spanish America, in the Río de la Plata region no nation-state existed until after midcentury. Powerful landowners and warlords ruled vast territories in a countryside populated by small guerrilla bands, bandits, cattle rustlers, itinerant ranch hands, and vagabonds. Even when frontiers were better defined toward the end of the nineteenth century, integrated nations failed to develop within defined boundaries. For many Indian people and racially heterogeneous *castas* in the countryside and towns, fighting for *la patria* did not mean the nation but "freedom," as during the independence wars.<sup>5</sup>

In most of Latin America, alternative, overlapping versions of *la patria* co-existed. This dilemma made armies the immediate arbiters of political debate. The vote of the bayonets was difficult to resist, but its victory over political argument and elections hindered political consensus while further embedding authoritarian and violent political practices and "solutions." Still, different histories implied development of distinctive military institutions from nation to nation.

## The Independence Wars and the First Generation of Military *Caudillos*

The independence wars brought carnage to Venezuela, quasi-race wars to Upper Peru (Bolivia), and royalist counterinsurgency campaigns to Mexico. In contrast, the struggle in Peru was relatively brief, with José de San Martín's combined Argentine-Chilean expedition invading by sea, and Simón Bolívar's armies from northern South America defeating the royalists. Estimates on the Mexican independence war dead range from 250,000 to 500,000 (some 5 to 10 percent of the population), and Venezuela suffered, proportionately, even more. Extensive economic destruction occurred in northern South America and Mexico alike. On the contrary, few died in Central American independence struggles. There, the infrastructure, such as it was, survived until the onset of later wars.

From Napoleon's invasion of the Iberian Peninsula in 1807–1808 to the 1820 military coup that prevented Ferdinand VII from sending reinforcements to his beleaguered forces in the Western Hemisphere, events in Spain influenced the fate of the Latin American independence movements. Spain managed to restore military and political control over the colonies from 1814 to 1817 except in the Río de la Plata provinces.<sup>6</sup> The reconquests that occurred in Chile and northern South America were vicious, with armies on both sides committing atrocities in the name of *la patria*. Bolívar declared "war to the death" against the Spaniards in 1813; various Spanish officers reciprocated, mercilessly torturing and massacring defeated rebels and civilians in the following years.

From 1810 to 1815, Spain never lost control in Peru, Mexico, Central America, Cuba, or Puerto Rico, but it suffered military setbacks in Río de la Plata, Chile, and northern South America. General Pablo Morillo's expeditionary force reestablished Spanish authority in Venezuela (1815) and Colombia (1816), and General Mariano Osorio temporarily reconquered Chile with reinforcements from Peru (1814–1817). Thereafter, rebels gradually defeated Spanish and loyalist armies in South America. Only to Venezuela and Colombia could Spain send a significant army, estimated at 10,000 troops, to reconquer its rebellious colonies. This force was fewer than the 15,000 troops that Portugal sent to Brazil after 1815, some of whom captured Montevideo in 1817, "to recover [for the Portuguese king] what in other times he possessed with a just title dating from the conquest, and which the crown of Castile wrested from him by violence."<sup>7</sup>

Despite Spanish invasions of northwestern Argentina (Salta) and battles in Chile from 1817 to 1821, the Río de la Plata provinces and Chile had gained their independence by 1818. After 1820, Spain lacked the military resources and political resolve to regain control. Internal strife and Colonel Rafael Riego's use of the army intended for colonial reconquest to instead reimpose the 1812 Constitution ended Spain's military prospects against the independence forces. Mexican independence came in 1821 as a reaction against the Spanish liberals who had offended the Church and decreed elimination of the military *fueros*. Peru did not fall until 1824, still not reinforced from Europe; Upper Peru (Bolivia) and some outposts on the Pacific coast, including Callao, held out until 1826. Spain retained Cuba and Puerto Rico. It did not recognize the indepen-

dence of any of its former colonies until relations were established with Mexico in 1836, three years after Fernando VII's death.

Strikingly, almost all the best known "liberators" of the colonies emerged from Spain's royal army and colonial militia (although some, such as Antonio José de Sucre and Felipe Santiago Salaverry, were too young to have served in Spanish ranks when the independence movements began). Venezuelans and Colombians played key roles in the liberation and early politics of Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia. And for the next several decades the presidents, would-be presidents, and political and military leaders came disproportionately from the generation of independence war officers, many of whom had fought on both sides before independence was won. Military chieftains from the independence wars became a sort of natural elite in the decades after separation from Spain.

In Mexico and Peru, where royal authority and armies persisted longest, former royalist officers played a particularly important role in the first half of the nineteenth century. In Mexico, of the 118 generals and colonels listed in 1840, 81 had started their careers in the royalist army (and only 12 had served in the insurgent armies).<sup>8</sup> In Peru and Bolivia, key military figures and presidents such as Andrés Santa Cruz and Agustín Gamarra served with the royalist forces until the 1820s, some even after San Martín's liberating army invaded the viceroyalty from Chile. While this situation did not hold everywhere, and many "military" leaders were appointed on the battlefields and by presidential decree, Table 2-1 indicates the Spanish military background of selected "liberators," well-known *caudillos*, and early national heroes.

The independence wars changed Spanish America in important ways: mobilizing the underclasses, upsetting traditional social lines, redistributing landed estates and urban property, routinizing brutality, diffusing weapons among the population, and making the leaders of armies the source of short-term political authority through the delegation of emergency powers and "extraordinary authority" (*facultades extraordinarias*). The wars produced the *caudillos* who would dominate vast areas of Latin America in the nineteenth century. They also set important precedents for the role of military forces in the region's international wars and internal conflicts during the next chaotic half-century.

First, both royalists and rebels relied extensively for cannon fodder on free blacks, slaves (who were promised freedom), *casta* peasants, ranch hands, cattle rustlers, bandits, vagabonds, and Indians. War also provided an opportunity for social mobility as mulattos, *mestizos*, and Indians served as officers. In Venezuela, Tomás Bovès led the racially mixed, royalist, *llanero* guerrilla cavalry against Bolívar's forces and became the rebels' "most terrible enemy" before a lance ended his time on Earth. On the rebel side, General Manuel Piar, a *pardo*, carried on the fight against the royalists in the east after a defeated Bolívar temporarily quit the country (1814-15) and fled to Jamaica and Haiti.

Piar's concern for race, perhaps even beyond his concern for independence, led him to challenge Bolívar's authority in 1817. Bolívar condemned him to death as a conspirator and rebel, fearing that racial antagonisms would threaten the independence struggle and, not incidentally, Bolívar's own star. In contrast, "General" Páez, a hardened plainsman who came to terms with Bolívar

Table 2-1. Selected Spanish American "Liberators" in Spain's Army and Militia

| Liberator                                             | Background                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| José Artigas (Uruguay)                                | Officer in the <i>Blandenques</i> anti-banditry unit stationed at Colonia, 1797-1818; fought against Portuguese; exiled in Paraguay after 1820.                                                                                                               |
| Simón Bolívar (Northern South America, Peru, Bolivia) | Most important independence leader in northern South America; served in militia of the Valleys of Aragua; royal commission as militia ensign, 1798.                                                                                                           |
| José Miguel Carrera (Chile)                           | Spanish army officer; fought in Spain, 1808-11; Chilean dictator in early independence movement.                                                                                                                                                              |
| Ramón Castilla (Peru)                                 | Cadet in Spanish army in Chile; taken prisoner at Battle of Chacabuco; escaped and returned to Peru in 1818; promoted to <i>alférez</i> ; joined San Martín's army in Peru; fought at Ayacucho against Spaniards.                                             |
| Juan José Flores (Venezuela, Ecuador)                 | Soldier in Morillo's Spanish army; switched sides after capture by rebels; Ecuador's first president (1830-34) and key political leader until midnineteenth century.                                                                                          |
| Agustín Gamarra (Peru)                                | Officer in Spanish army until 1821; Peru's president (1829-33, 1839-41) and military <i>caudillo</i> ; died at Battle of Ingavi in 1841 against Bolivians while seeking to merge Bolivia, or part of it, into Peru.                                           |
| Martín Güemes (Argentina, Salta)                      | Entered Spanish army at age fourteen; in Salta 1799-1805, then in Buenos Aires fighting against British invasion in 1806; went over to independence movement in 1810; killed in 1821.                                                                         |
| Agustín de Iturbide (Mexico)                          | High-ranking royalist officer until 1821; directed counterinsurgency campaign against rebels until going over to independence movement and becoming "emperor" of Mexico.                                                                                      |
| José de la Mar (Peru)                                 | Spanish officer; fought against French; brigadier in 1814; joined rebels after fall of Callao, 1821; as Peru's president (1827-29), led Peruvian anti-Bolivarian faction in war against Colombia (1828-30); exiled to Costa Rica after being deposed by coup. |

|                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Antonio López de Santa Anna<br>(Mexico)     | Royalist army commander and subaltern of Iturbide; overturned Iturbide's "empire"; many-term president of Mexico.                                                                                                                                        |
| Francisco de Miranda (Venezuela)            | Captain in infantry company in 1772; fought in North Africa; served in Cuba, Florida (against British in Spanish army supporting U.S. independence movement), and the Bahamas; left service in 1783, accused of spying for British and contraband trade. |
| José María Obando (Colombia)                | Royalist guerrilla leader; switched sides and became <i>caudillo</i> in southwestern provinces; president of Colombia (1853).                                                                                                                            |
| Joaquín Prieto Vial (Chile)                 | Lieutenant in Spanish cavalry in Chile, 1805; Chilean president, 1831-41.                                                                                                                                                                                |
| José de la Riva-Agüero (Peru)               | Short service with Spanish army before 1809; briefly Peruvian president after independence.                                                                                                                                                              |
| Bernardino Rivadavia (Argentina)            | Colonial militia; fought against British in 1806-07 invasion; leading unitarist in Buenos Aires and "Argentine" president; ousted during war against Brazil (1827) by federalist <i>caudillos</i> ; sent into exile.                                     |
| José de San Martín (Argentina, Chile, Peru) | Served in Spanish army from 1789-1811 in Spain, France, Portugal, and North Africa; "supreme protector" of Peru (1822).                                                                                                                                  |
| Andrés Santa Cruz (Bolivia, Peru)           | Officer in Spanish army until 1820 when captured at Battle of Cerro de Pasco; briefly interim president of Peru (1827) and founder of Peru-Bolivia Federation (1836-39); plotted return to Bolivia from exile and creation of monarchy in South America. |

but never became subordinate, raised a patriot *llanero* force in Apure. He commanded the same sort of mixed-race irregular cavalry in the name of independence that Boves used against Bolívar. These *llaneros*, like those under Boves, fought out of loyalty to their leaders, for plunder, and for freedom of their plains from government control. They became the most important political currency in Venezuela, eventually helping to make Páez the nation's first president and its most important politico-military *caudillo* for the next two decades.

Aware of the volatility of the race question, Bolívar attempted to convince the troops that his revolution gave them what Piar pretended: "Have not our armies broken the chains of the slaves? Has not the odious distinction between

classes and colours been abolished forever? Have I not ordered national property to be distributed among you? Are you not equal, free, independent, happy and respected?"<sup>9</sup> The answer, in Venezuela as in most of Latin America, was *no!* But the army did offer more opportunities than elsewhere. While the wars lasted, mobility seemed possible and equality plausible. In most of the region, however, slavery endured much beyond independence, and racial discrimination persisted unabated. *Criollos* incorporated successful military *caudillos* into the landowning classes, making these new *latifundistas* less interested in social reform than in consolidating their position in the old social hierarchy. Examples abound. Páez the *llanero* became a great Venezuelan cattle baron and conservative president. Flores, a Venezuelan upstart, married into the Quito aristocracy, served as independent Ecuador's first president, and later favored monarchy.

Indians, the recipients of unkept promises by both loyalists and patriots, also served both sides in the independence wars. The *cacique* Pumacahua, for example, who had fought against Túpac Amaru in the 1780s, joined rebel forces in Peru and Upper Peru. At La Paz the Spanish garrison was slaughtered; in Arequipa the intendant and other prisoners were shot. By mid-1815, however, the Spanish reconquest was complete and the leading rebels, including Pumacahua, were executed. In contrast, at Ayacucho in 1824, Indians fought on the royalist side in the losing cause against Sucre's Venezuelan-Ecuadorian polychromatic army. Indian, black, and *casta* troops bled for both sides, with their own objectives and dreams, but were never able to wrest permanent social and economic gains from either one.

Even in the most important campaigns, armies rarely exceeded 8,000 men, and, more typically, "battles" involved 500 to 2,000 combatants. Some 500 to 1,500 slaves, free blacks, and Indians made up an army. The "armada" of seven warships and less than twenty transports that carried San Martín's liberating expedition to Peru, for example, brought an army of 4,500, and Bolívar's combined Peruvian, Colombian, Venezuelan, and Chilean force that liberated Peru reached 8,000. The soldiers were always darker-skinned than most of their officers, the *criollo* elites, the Spanish loyalists, and the British, other European, and sometimes U.S. mercenaries.

The character of warfare and of military service promoted disrespect for traditional social lines, allowed upward mobility for selected war heroes and troops, and offered widespread redistribution of land and wealth. Spanish commanders and royal officials confiscated *haciendas*, cattle, horses, and provisions from supporters of the independence movements; rebels did the same against loyalists. Both sides abused, tortured, and executed prisoners—military and civilian, men, women, and children. They confiscated property to finance their campaigns and to stuff their own pockets. Descriptions of savagery, repression, and abuse by loyalists and patriots abound. In 1810 in Upper Peru (Bolivia), the liberating army "initiated a rule of terror which soon alerted even the patriots. Royal officials were shot, Spaniards penalized, . . . the auxiliary army was on the rampage, terrorizing anyone who stood in its way."<sup>10</sup> In Venezuela in 1814–15, "the counterrevolution imposed itself as a violent reconquest. Many patriots were punished; some were executed . . . rebels were defined widely enough to include leaders, supporters, passive followers, and emigrants.

... In 1815 over three hundred haciendas were taken from creole rebels.<sup>11</sup> To the west, in Colombia in 1815, "Morillo landed his expedition at Santa Marta in July 1815. Cartagena maintained a suicidal resistance to a siege which lasted a hundred days, and was finally occupied on 6 December; the town was dead, its streets littered with corpses, and the few patriots still alive were butchered by the loyalists."<sup>12</sup>

These practices affected *criollo* and Spanish elites alike, temporarily upsetting the clear hierarchical socio-racial lines that separated the white peak of colonial society from the colored masses at the bottom. Although *criollos* sought to reestablish traditional social domination in the decades after independence, the armed forces, more than any other institution, permitted political and economic mobility for some who had been excluded by the colonial order. *Caudillo* presidents, generals, colonels, and garrison commanders used their military power to offset their lack of social status and to acquire economic resources. The old *criollo* elite's disdain for these new officers underlay a festering civil-military tension that survived into the twentieth century. In the decades after independence the "race question" and the "Indian question" gave the armed forces an often unspoken *razón de ser* (reason for being): to defend towns, cities, haciendas, and "civilization" itself against the ever-present threat of slave and Indian uprisings, wars by hostile tribes (especially in Argentina, Chile, and Mexico), and disorder by the urban *castas*. Loss of the political legitimacy and "social peace" imposed by Spain made post-independence political leaders and economic elites much more dependent on the armed forces for maintaining internal order than had been the colonial regime.

A second important change resulting from the independence wars was the widespread diffusion of weapons, militias, guerrilla bands, and military jurisdiction. Vast territories were subjected to martial law for decades. Military commanders, under emergency decrees or self-conferred authority, peremptorily disposed of property and lives. The military's jurisdiction over civilians, and its immunity from civil authority and courts, established a self-perpetuating culture of arrogance and domination legitimated by appeals to defend *la patria*, God, liberty, and independence (or monarchism, in the case of loyalists) against their enemies. Military orders were law; there existed no legal counterbalance, judicial remedy, or accountability when abuses occurred. Impunity prevailed, became the norm, and buttressed the armed forces' role in post-colonial society. This jurisdiction included regular armies, regional militias, and local *caudillo* bands commanded by landowners and so-called colonels.

In largely agrarian societies with the population concentrated in and around huge landed estates, politics, law enforcement, and political authority outside the cities and towns depended on armed force. National politics, to the extent that such existed, depended on controlling, balancing, and co-opting the dispersed military bands within the country. Inability to establish political order and effective law enforcement, widespread banditry, racial and social antagonisms, conflicts over land and water, and widespread corruption reinforced the importance and pervasiveness of the military role. And desertion, mutinies, scavenging, and brigandage were common in armies composed of forcibly recruited peasants, former slaves, vagrants, ranch hands, and town dwellers: "Most of the Colombian cavalry ... was originally mounted on horses

seized from private owners. Such exactions . . . could at least be justified by reasons of military necessity. . . . There were always some exactions, on the other hand, that can be classed as simple robbery for the benefit of individual officers and men. . . . Indeed a very high proportion of the crimes of violence committed during the decade of Gran Colombia [1821-1830] were cases involving the military."<sup>13</sup>

The new states were left with "virtual armies of occupation, whose function was principally the welfare of their own members."<sup>14</sup> Like many of the new Spanish American nations, Gran Colombia spent from 50 to 75 percent of its budget to finance the armed forces even as the nation sank further into debt. With Spain unreconciled to the loss of its colonies, a persuasive rationale existed to maintain national armies and militia. Into the 1840s, Spain plotted a return to northern South America and actually reestablished colonial rule in the Dominican Republic from 1861 to 1865. It also seized Peru's Chincha Islands, the source of guano, its main export; occupied Callao in 1864; and in 1866 bombarded Chile's main port, Valparaíso.<sup>15</sup> Recurrent foreign intervention and regional and civil wars reinforced the habits of military preponderance acquired from 1810 to 1826.

Related to the diffusion of weapons, militia, irregular armies, and banditry was a third feature of the independence wars that gave a predominant political role to the military: early Spanish American political charters and constitutions fused civil and military authority in powerful, virtually dictatorial executives. Constitutions typically gave these executives extraordinary powers to meet emergencies, assure internal security, and respond to external threats. These constitutional regimes of exception permitted suspension of civil liberties and rights, allowed confiscation of property, and inspired general contempt for due process and the rule of law. They initiated the Spanish American tradition of constitutional dictatorship. Typical examples of such legitimation of dictatorship were the 1814 *Reglamento para el Gobierno Provisorio* for Chile that gave the "supreme director" "full and unrestricted authority" (*facultades amplísimas e ilimitadas*), and the 1821 Constitution for Gran Colombia that vested in the chief executive "those extraordinary powers deemed indispensable."<sup>16</sup> This Gran Colombian charter authorized that "in times of internal commotion and armed conflict endangering the security of the Republic," the president take "whatever extraordinary measures, not within the normal sphere of his authority, that the case may require." Similarly, San Martín made himself "supreme protector" of Peru, explaining: "On my arrival at Pisco, I announced, that, owing to the imperative circumstances, I found myself invested with the Supreme Authority, and that I was responsible to the Country for the exercise of it: Circumstances have not changed, because Peru still has internal Enemies to combat; and it is consequently necessary that the political and military command should continue in my person."<sup>17</sup>

With president-generals on the battlefield and their regional and local commanders exercising war powers, policymaking, administration, and execution came frequently from the saddle rather than from the congress and bureaucracy. Flores, for example, exercised "supreme military and civil authority" in Quito from 1825 to 1830 while heading an occupation army. When the independence wars were won, the cattle-baron "colonels" and "generals" who

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emerged from the rebel armies were rewarded with land grants for their service to *la patria*. They continued making policy and administering their version of justice. These were the *caudillos*, the men on horseback with irregular armies who dominated Latin America for much of the nineteenth century.

*Caudillismo* meant "the rule by any kind of pre-eminent leader who derived authority more by an ability, through force of character and patronage, to command the loyalty of a substantial band of armed followers, than from adherence to the rule of law or the constitution."<sup>18</sup> *Caudillos* "used violence or the threat of violence for political ends—whether as a professional officer commanding regular army units, or as a militia officer or civilian on horseback leading militia or irregular forces into battle, or (more broadly) as an essentially civilian leader who engaged in violent repression."<sup>19</sup> These *caudillos* proudly displayed military rank; most were not professional soldiers. Nineteenth-century Latin America was dominated by *caudillos*, violence, and the military, but not by professional armed forces. The beginnings of truly professional armies, with officers sharing common doctrines, knowledge, skills, and esprit de corps acquired in war academies and technical schools, would not appear until after the mid-1870s.

The *caudillos* inherited both the loyalist and Bolivarian tradition of "war to the death" against adversaries, always fighting in the name of liberty and some "ism" (republicanism, unitarism, federalism) and against evil enemies (unitarists, federalists, liberals, godless subversives, Catholic fanatics, Freemasons, and other targets of opportunity). Juan Manuel de Rosas, for example, the most famous of Argentina's conservative, pro-clerical, and federalist *caudillos* who dominated Buenos Aires and the interior from 1829 to 1852, ruled with "extraordinary powers." He had his portrait placed on church pulpits, outlawed the opposition press and "political writings," and used a secret police (the *mazorca*) to murder and intimidate opponents under the banner (which appeared on public documents), "Death to the Savage Unitarians." Rosas assembled a more or less permanent army camped outside of Buenos Aires that became the ultimate basis of his power.<sup>20</sup> To the north, Colombia's liberal president, Francisco de Paula Santander (1832–1837), who had opposed Bolívar's dictatorial style, implacably repressed "traitors" who conspired against his government. Thus, a plot in 1833 by a purged general, José Sardá, resulted in "his being tracked down by loyal officers who were admitted to his hideaway on the pretense of wanting to join his movement—and instead shot him in cold blood. . . . Santander's enemies raised a hue and cry over the unnecessary cruelty used, but Santander refused to reprimand his subordinates. By that time seventeen others had already been shot in the main square of Bogotá, as Santander (who rejected the court's recommendation of clemency in seven of the cases) watched through an office window."<sup>21</sup>

Repression could be ordered in the name of any convenient "ism," any cause, any high-sounding principle. Always, the *caudillo* in power (and his opponents) justified the quest for power, patronage, and personal aggrandizement and the need to kill, repress, exile, and confiscate property from their adversaries with defense of *la patria*, and with the particular political slogans of the moment (some might say ideology, such as liberalism and conservatism, but this seems too exaggerated a claim for most early nineteenth-century

*caudillos*). Whatever the cause, lances, bayonets, swords, the gallows, firing squads, prisons, and exile were the main political instruments.

Those exiled sometimes provided vivid descriptions of *caudillo* heavy-handedness. Future Argentine president Domingo Sarmiento published *Facundo* (1845) from exile in Chile. It was a passionate attack on *caudillo* barbarism and the politics of terror that became a classic interpretation of politics and culture in the first half of the nineteenth century: "Let us not deceive ourselves: terror is a means of government which produces greater results than patriotism and fervor."<sup>22</sup> Of course, years later as governor of the province of San Juan, Sarmiento, the liberal champion of civilization against *caudillo* barbarism, justified this politics of terror in fighting banditry and rebels. When his militia captured, killed, and displayed on a pole the head of Angel V. Peñaloza, the *caudillo* from La Rioja, Sarmiento wrote to President Bartolomé Mitre: "If we had not cut off the head of that inveterate scoundrel and placed it on display, the mob would not have quieted down in six months."<sup>23</sup>

Applying emergency powers and military ordinances against political opponents, "subversives," and bandits became routine—indeed, the most ubiquitous feature in nineteenth-century Spanish American politics. The independence wars and their constitutions thus provided the legal rationale for presidentialism and dictatorship as well as for the preeminent role of the armed forces in politics. They also nurtured an infant militarism that gradually came to pervade Latin America, even when presidents such as Santander in Colombia opposed large standing armies and military political involvement.

A fourth legacy of the independence wars assured another important role for the region's armed forces: border wars and defense against periodic military interventions by European nations. Spain's colonial territories had been poorly demarcated, and administrative jurisdictions had been frequently reconfigured. The principle of *uti possidetis* (right to possession) provided that "republican governments are being founded within the limits of the former viceroalties, captaincies general, or presidencies."<sup>24</sup> But which limits, and where were they? And what of smaller jurisdictions, such as Quito and Charcas? And what of disputed jurisdictions such as those across the river from Buenos Aires (the *banda oriental*) that would later become Uruguay? These questions fueled decades of conflict, border disputes, all-out wars, intervention by *caudillos* supporting their allies across "international" frontiers, and therefore the need for military forces to defend territorial and jurisdictional claims.

International wars could not be distinguished entirely from internal wars and disputes among rival *caudillos*, particularly in Central America, Peru, Ecuador, Colombia, and the Río de la Plata region until the 1860s. Unsettled claims of the independence wars encouraged militarization of Latin American politics, and foreign military intervention made it unavoidable. Battles between contending *caudillos* within "nations" made border disputes elements of internal political conflict and international war. Before the dissolution of Gran Colombia and Bolívar's death (1830), for example, battles between his allies and anti-Bolivarians made civil wars and separatist struggles inseparable from Bolívar's personal project to consolidate "the basis of the social compact, which ought to form of this world a nation of republics."<sup>25</sup>

No "nation of republics" emerged, but fighting the independence wars and the post-independence conflicts was expensive. A fifth legacy was the high cost of financing the military campaigns, the debt accumulated, the excessive expense of maintaining armies and paying pensions to retired officers, the emergence of war as a source of business opportunity for the favored, and the accumulation of grievances by uncompensated and defrauded veterans. Internal and foreign loans partly financed the destruction and butchery. Nonpayment of the debts accumulated in independence wars and post-independence disorder motivated conflicts among the new Spanish American nations and also invited foreign intervention. European powers sent military expeditions to defend their nationals, force payment of private and public debts, avenge supposed diplomatic slights, and enforce their commercial and territorial claims. Occasionally, they were also invited by Latin American factions to support their cause against internal rivals, thus provoking military responses by "nationalists" and would-be presidents. *La patria* rarely lacked external military threats—from Europe, other Latin American nations, and the United States.

In all of these conflicts, the post-independence *caudillos* and their small irregular cavalry bands found opportunities to wield knives, machetes, and lances to defend *la patria*, the constitution, and other sacred causes—and to profit from their service if they won the battle. Wars, big and small, meant opportunity for gaining land, booty, and social mobility. For many Latin Americans this was the only chance, or the best one, for bettering their lot. Although war offered soldiers opportunities for social mobility and economic rewards, from the time of the independence wars governments frequently failed to keep their promises to veterans. Abolition of slavery, land grants, pensions, patronage, and other enticements for wartime service eluded retired soldiers. Worse still, presidents and *caudillos* purged the ranks of opponents and rewarded their personal followers, making "politics" an enemy of the wounded, betrayed, and cashiered. Páez, for example, had persuaded Bolívar to promise bonuses ranging from 500 pesos for common soldiers to 25,000 pesos for a *general en jefe*. While Páez and Santander benefited handsomely, acquiring large confiscated estates, many soldiers and officers received little, if any, of the promised benefits. Festered resentment produced political malcontents, bandits, and opposing armies. Corruption, speculation in the vouchers (*vales*) for land and currency sometimes distributed to veterans, and outright fraud further lowered government credibility. Although some veterans in all the nations received recompense for their patriotic service (and some generals fabulous rewards in land and money), the mass of veterans had the unreliability and venality of government proved to them most painfully. Political influence was usually needed to obtain promised patronage, promotions, and pensions. Political "outs" could count on nothing. How could military officers not be involved in politics?

Sixth, conflicts arose over the constitutional, political, and professional status of the military in the new nations. Debates of varying intensity in each nation took place on the perpetuation or elimination of military *fueros*, on the extent of military jurisdiction over civilians, on the propriety and desirability of suffrage for officers and common soldiers, and on the merits of militia versus standing regular armies. Military budgets strained impoverished, indebted

governments, and efforts to demobilize and shrink the independence armies threatened social peace when soldiers returned to the countryside and towns without land, jobs, or prospects.

Political supporters, including officers, could be rewarded from the public coffers and promoted at presidential whim (although sometimes legislative approval was required). Political opponents, including officers, could be stripped of command, demoted, cashiered from service, and exiled, their property confiscated and their families persecuted. The stakes for political losers were high and the risks substantial enough to make control of violence literally worth everything. Each shift in government potentially threatened catastrophe or proffered a windfall. Until this situation changed, the loyalty and effectiveness of both regular armies and irregular bands would make the difference between presidents and corpses, between opulence and poverty, between tranquility and exile, between life and death. Officers could lose and win their commands, be promoted and stationed in the capital, or sent to the provinces and penury as the result of political fate. With politics so crucial to their personal and professional lives, and so volatile, "liberty, equality and fraternity gave way to infantry, cavalry, and artillery, as the republics bled themselves in constant warfare."<sup>26</sup>

Appointments of generals and colonels by presidents and ranking officers multiplied, thus derailing efforts to limit military expenditures and to professionalize the officer corps. Indeed, prior to the 1870s, or even the end of the century when European missions were contracted to develop more professional military organizations, armies in Central America and elsewhere "were the *caudillos'* personal militia, composed of ill-disciplined and low-paid rabble who enjoyed privilege and prestige of a sort, but also evoked universal disdain and fear."<sup>27</sup>

Discipline in these armies was brutal; beatings, whippings of from one hundred to five hundred lashes, and other savage punishments were common. Such treatment was passed on to miscreants, bandits, and enemies with whom the troops came into contact. Soldiers who were not ranch hands on the *caudillos'* personal estates were frequently "recruited," as noted earlier, from the ranks of slaves, as punishment for vagrancy, or directly from the prisons. Military duty was itself a punishment for many crimes; serving *la patria* was often not voluntary. Illustrative were the crocodile tears shed by Uruguay's Colonel León Palleja in 1853: "I deplore as anyone the terrible necessity of corporal punishment prescribed by our military laws. But take a look at the people in our army: they are composed for the most part of indolent African slaves accustomed to brute force; only in that way will they clean themselves and comply with the duties of a soldier, and [others] even worse, recruited from the jails. And it is desired to eliminate [whippings]? First, reform the personnel in the Army and get rid of these criminals."<sup>28</sup> This phenomenon was "not exclusive to Uruguay, but was more or less common . . . to all of Latin America in the decades after the definitive expulsion of the Spaniards."<sup>29</sup>

With no requirement that officers had to obtain professional training at military academies and with virtually no specialized schools (later called *escuelas de clase*, or *escuelas de suboficiales*) for noncommissioned officers, the military was inherently politicized, both as a resource of ambitious political

leaders and in the dependence of officers on political circumstances for career advancement. Both of these factors irritated the small corps of military careerists who aspired to more patriotic and autonomous professional roles. This system of patronage made armies political instruments and politicians dependent on military intervention in politics—all justified by the reverent and ritual invocation of *la patria*.

### "International" Wars and Internal Conflicts in the Early Nineteenth Century

Spanish America and Brazil went without pause from independence wars to a series of post-independence territorial and boundary disputes (see Map 2-1), wars with European nations, and civil wars. The confusion of these conflicts allowed all sides to claim patriotic inspiration as they killed, confiscated property, despoiled the countryside, sought to erect personalist fiefdoms, and endeavored to define the territorial boundaries of the new nations and the type of political systems that would govern Latin America. Roughly, such wars fell into four main overlapping categories: 1) transnational wars of political consolidation (those that determined the political existence and territory of nascent republics, including secession wars) (Table 2-2); 2) international wars (those between existing countries over other than boundary issues and territory, which nonetheless might involve transfer of territory from losers to victors) (Table 2-3); 3) wars against European military intervention, including Spanish efforts to restore imperial authority (Table 2-4); and 4) civil wars.

A table listing civil wars and rebellions in nineteenth-century Latin America, even if such a list could be accurately compiled (and this is not likely), would require an additional volume. Historian David Bushnell, for example, lists eleven "national level rebellions" in nineteenth-century Colombia. He adds: "Indeed, what was a civil war? . . . And should one—could one—count all the outbreaks whose immediate aim was to overthrow only regional authorities?"<sup>30</sup> Dana Munro comments on Bolivia that after the overthrow of Sucre (1827-28), "nearly every change of government had been the result of a mutiny in the army, and every officer of the higher ranks had come to regard himself as a potential dictator."<sup>31</sup> Peru's most insightful historian, Jorge Basadre, counts thirteen military uprisings in Bolivia from June to October 1840,<sup>32</sup> and "Mexico had sixteen presidents and thirty-three provisional national leaders, a total of forty-nine administrations in thirty-three years."<sup>33</sup> Not even Brazil escaped post-independence political violence:

The regency had already suffered from a rash of rebellions . . . in Maranhão (1831-32), Bahia (1832-1835), Minas Gerais (1833), and Mato Grosso (1834). The *Cabanagem* revolt in Pará began in January 1835 and continued until 1837, leaving the province in ruins. . . . it degenerated into a senseless orgy of murder and pillage. Later in 1835 the most serious revolt of all began—the Farroupilha, or War of the Ragamuffins, in Rio Grande do Sul. The *farrapos*, so-called because of the fringed leather they wore on the cattle ranges, were influenced by some of the separatist currents in the Río de la Plata region, for Rio Grande do Sul bordered on Uruguay, and neither side paid much attention to international boundaries.<sup>34</sup>

Table 2-2. Transnational Wars of Political Consolidation and Secession, 1825-1870

| <i>Wars</i>                                                                    | <i>Motivations/Outcomes</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mexican Empire/Central America (1823)                                          | Vicente Filísola sent by Emperor Iturbide to conquer El Salvador and incorporate it into the empire; fighting erupts in Nicaragua, Costa Rica; Central America declares independence, July 1823; Chiapas remains with Mexico.                                                                             |
| Brazil/Buenos Aires (1825-28)                                                  | Creates independent Uruguay; Brazilian and Provincias Unidas (Argentine) "guarantee" of independence until 1835.                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Colombia-Peru (1828-30)<br>(also Bolivia, "Ecuador")                           | No real settlement of outstanding boundary issues; dissolution of Gran Colombia, creation of Ecuador, 1830.                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Peru-Bolivia Confederation/Chile, Río de la Plata provinces (1836-39)          | Dissolution of Peru-Bolivia Confederation; consolidation of conservative regime in Chile; renewed civil wars in Peru and Bolivia; Rosas defeats rivals in Río de la Plata.                                                                                                                                |
| Provincias Unidas/Uruguay (1838-51)<br>Known in Uruguay as "La Guerra Grande"  | Coincides with French blockade (1838-40); partly Fructuoso Rivera versus Rosas, partly battle over territory, partly Rosas's refusal to recognize Uruguayan independence, partly continuation of civil wars—Rosas versus Anti-Rosistas (1838-51).                                                         |
| Dissolution of Central American Confederation (1838-65)                        | Intermittent war between Conservatives led by Rafael Carrera in Guatemala (1839-65) and Liberals; Liberal Francisco Morazán attempts to restore federation, 1842; defeated and executed.                                                                                                                  |
| Panama/New Granada (1840-41)                                                   | Panama declares its independence; remains autonomous for two years.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Peru/Bolivia (1841)                                                            | Peruvian <i>caudillo</i> Agustín Gamarra invades Bolivia; defeated by Gen. José Ballivián. An extension of the Peru-Bolivia Confederation war, with Gamarra seeking to incorporate part or all of Bolivia under Peruvian control. Gamarra killed in battle at Ingavi. War confirms Bolivian independence. |
| Brazil, Uruguay, Río de la Plata factions against Rosas in Buenos Aires (1851) | Argentine <i>caudillo</i> Justo José de Urquiza with internal allies and support from Brazilian emperor, Uruguayan factions, and exiled unitarists. In part a continuation of the "Guerra Grande."                                                                                                        |
| Guatemala/El Salvador (1863)                                                   | Carrera invades El Salvador and replaces Gerardo Barrios with Conservative Francisco Dueñas.                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Guatemala, Honduras/El Salvador (1871)                                         | Dueñas defeated and Field Marshal Santiago González made president.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

Table 2-3. Western Hemisphere International Wars, 1826-1885

| Wars                                                                      | Motivations/Outcomes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chile/Peru-Bolivia Confederation (1836-39)                                | Chile and Rosas defeat Provincias Unidas, Andrés Santa Cruz; Peru and Bolivia separated; war between Peruvian and Bolivian <i>caudillos</i> continues until 1841.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| United States/Mexico (1845-48)                                            | Extension of Texas independence war (1836) and U.S. intent to annex territory. Simultaneous internal federalist-centralist wars in Mexico. Country loses vast northern territory; Mexico City occupied.                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| War of the Triple Alliance, Paraguayan War (1864-70)                      | Paraguay devastated by Brazilian, Argentine, and Uruguayan armies. War begins, in part, as Paraguayan protest against Brazilian meddling in Uruguayan politics and Paraguayan invasion across Argentine territory to defend political allies. Also involves long-standing border and territorial disputes between Argentina-Paraguay, Paraguay-Brazil. Paraguay loses disputed territories after military defeat. |
| War of the Pacific (1879-84)                                              | Chilean defense of economic interests and treaty rights against Bolivian government; "secret treaty" brings Peru into war; Bolivia loses its seacoast and Peru its southernmost province.                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Guatemala (now under Liberal rule of Gen. Justo Rufino Barrios) (1876-85) | Periodic interventions in Central American states; failed effort to restore federation under Guatemalan tutelage; Barrios killed in battle in El Salvador, 1885.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

Rebel military officers deposed presidents, closed congresses, called constitutional conventions, overthrew emperors (in Mexico and Brazil), and fought one another. Armed force was the political instrument of choice; *golpes de cuartel* (barracks uprisings) and general civil wars caused frequent changes of government. These struggles could be short and bloodless, but they could also be protracted and messy, as in many of the Argentine and Uruguayan "internal" wars from the 1830s until after the Paraguayan War (1864-1870).

All four types of armed conflict sometimes involved European intervention, meddling across frontiers by rival *caudillos* supporting their allies in neighboring nations, and *caudillos* in exile joining with invading armies to overthrow their enemies at home. The conflicts involved contention over the very definition of "national" and international matters in addition to disputes over internal policies (Church versus state, federalism versus centralism, tariffs, taxation, Indian lands). They were also struggles over power, patronage, and the national purse, but these cannot be dismissed simply as unprincipled combat among military *caudillos*, although sometimes such was the case. Some *caudillos* "expressed a realistic sense of nationalism which defined the nation in terms

Table 2-4. Major Foreign Interventions, 1826-1885

| <i>Wars</i>                                               | <i>Motivations/Outcomes</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Spain in Mexico (1829)                                    | Spanish king sends expedition as retribution for law expelling Spaniards; Spanish invade at Tampico, defeated by yellow fever and General Santa Anna.                                                                                          |
| Britain takes Malvinas Islands (renamed Falklands) (1833) | Argentina still claims these islands; most recent war to recover them in 1982.                                                                                                                                                                 |
| France in Río de la Plata (1838-40)                       | French blockade Buenos Aires to protect commercial interests; withdraw after two years, agree to arbitration.                                                                                                                                  |
| France in Mexico (1838)                                   | The "Pastry War"; brief incursion to support claims of French citizens.                                                                                                                                                                        |
| France and Britain in Río de la Plata (1840-45)           | French and British blockade La Plata to protect nationals, defend commerce, support Rosas's Uruguayan and Argentine enemies. Military base created on an island and in Uruguay. Rosas prevails; British and French withdraw (1847-48).         |
| Britain in Central America (1843-50)                      | British government assumes Mosquitia protectorate (1843); British occupy San Juan del Norte, rename it Greytown (1848-50); British occupy Tigre Island in Gulf of Fonseca (1849).                                                              |
| United States/Nicaragua (1854)                            | U.S. Navy bombards Greytown.                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Filibuster Expedition (1855-60)                           | William Walker arrives in Nicaragua; assists Liberals, becomes president in 1856; after ouster, Walker mounts new expeditions; captured and executed in 1860.                                                                                  |
| Spain in Dominican Republic (1861-65)                     | Spain reimposes colonial rule at request of Dominican president, who becomes captain-general; withdraws after U.S. Civil War and internal resistance make colony indefensible.                                                                 |
| Britain in Central America (1862)                         | Belize settlement becomes British colony of British Honduras.                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| France, Spain, Britain in Mexico (1862)                   | Europeans intervene to protect nationals in Mexico; Spanish and British withdraw; French establish an "empire" under Maximilian until 1867.                                                                                                    |
| Spain/Peru, Chile, Ecuador, Bolivia (1865-66)             | Spanish naval squadron takes Chincha Islands, Peru's main source of foreign exchange (from guano deposits); formal declarations of war from Peru, Chile, Ecuador, Bolivia. Spain attacks Valparaíso, Callao, and Ecuadorian ports; hostilities |

|                                                         |                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                         | formally suspended in 1871. Spain and Peru sign peace treaty in 1879.                                  |
| Britain in Central America (1894–95)                    | Last intervention on Mosquitia coast. U.S. mediation ends British blockade of Corinto, Nicaragua.      |
| United States/Spain (1898–1902)<br>Spanish-American War | United States intervenes in Cuban independence movement; defeats Spain, occupies Cuba and Puerto Rico. |

of immediate interests. They responded effectively to external threat, either of neighbors or of foreign powers. And in defending the resources of their country against outsiders, they were forced to apply a distinction between natives and foreigners.<sup>35</sup> Rosas in Buenos Aires and the Blanco faction *caudillos* in Uruguay (beginning with José Antonio Lavalleja, and then Manuel Oribe) were identified with a nationalist, rural-nativist, anti-European, and anti-cosmopolitan spirit that became an integral part of Argentine and Uruguayan nationalism. Peruvian, Bolivian, and Chilean *caudillos* in the wars from 1836 to 1841 also fought to create and master new *patrias*; Santa Cruz, Gamarra, José Ballivián, and Manuel Bulnes all served as generals, presidents, and icons of national histories constructed later. These early nineteenth-century wars made armies—often only key garrisons—political arbiters. Civilians of all parties, factions, and opinions were dependent on military force to achieve personal and political objectives. They encouraged military intervention on their own behalf.

Two illustrative cases of early nineteenth-century transnational wars of political consolidation are the conflict that created an independent Uruguay (1825–1828) and that of the Peru-Bolivia Confederation against Chile and Rosas's Río de la Plata confederation (1836–1839). In each one, national territory and boundaries were at stake, as was the very existence of a nation-state. These core issues were complicated by internal political and ideological conflicts, personal feuds, regionalism, and cross-national *caudillo* alliances. In the Uruguayan case, wars were waged almost continuously from the 1830s to the end of the War of the Triple Alliance in 1870. Almost all of the wars were international as well as internal, involving "surrogate foreign forces and alien armies."<sup>36</sup> Intriguingly, the endemic Uruguayan guerrilla wars were called *patriadas* (wars for *la patria*); they were "such a common occurrence that guerrilla warfare was perceived in the rural areas as a 'natural' feature of political life." This was also true in Bolivia and Peru, and even in Chile, if somewhat less so after the mid-1830s.<sup>37</sup>

Even a bare-bones description of these nineteenth-century wars into the 1860s requires mention of the *caudillos* who fought for power and patronage within the territories not yet consolidated as nation-states. Their names clutter the story of nation-building and are tedious for readers; without them the wars make no sense, but the wars were not merely personal conflicts without complex cultural, racial, economic, national, and international motives. And in these wars former colonies gradually became internationally recognized nation-states. Latin American *patrias* emerged from the bloodshed and strife of the first half of the nineteenth century.

## Later Nineteenth-Century Wars

By the 1860s the rough shapes of Latin American nation-states had been carved out, although territorial disputes, dreams of reunifying fragmented colonial jurisdictions, and transnational political meddling persisted. Two regional conflicts in the last part of the century, the War of the Triple Alliance against Paraguay and the Chilean defeat of Peru and Bolivia in the War of the Pacific, again readjusted boundaries but confirmed the essentials of the evolved South American nation-state system. In Central America the defeat in 1885 of Guatemala's Justo Rufino Barrios in his efforts to reunify the isthmus solidified the autonomous existence of Costa Rica, Nicaragua, Honduras, El Salvador, and Guatemala.

These later wars were more clearly international conflicts, and their devastating outcomes for the losers (and the winners' fears of revenge) pushed Latin Americans toward more modern, professional armed forces after the 1880s. Brutally demonstrating the cost of unpreparedness, military weakness, and poor political leadership, these wars further politicized the armed forces and created demands for military and economic modernization, European military missions, and reform of national politics.

### *The War of the Triple Alliance, 1864–1870*

In many ways the Paraguayan War was similar to previous transnational *caudillo* intermeddling and an extension of the Brazilian-Argentine tutelage and intervention in Uruguay from the time of the 1825–1828 war that created that country. It also involved long-standing territorial conflicts between Paraguay and its two larger neighbors. From the 1840s, Paraguay, Buenos Aires, and Brazil had sparred over control of the rivers of the Río de la Plata system. The French-British military interventions (1838–1840; 1845–1850), Rosas's periodic efforts to blockade Montevideo, and Paraguay's autarchic development and security policies adversely affected regional commerce and politics. Unresolved bilateral conflicts between Brazil and Paraguay over river access, including Paraguayan incursions into Brazil, and between Paraguay and Rosas's confederation, such as military penetration of Corrientes province (in support of local *caudillos* against Rosas), simmered until the early 1860s.

In 1863 the former Uruguayan president and leader of the Colorado party, General Venancio Flores, returned from Argentina to challenge the Blanco party government at Montevideo. He was joined by volunteers from Corrientes and Entre Ríos provinces and assisted by the Brazilian government. Brazil and Argentina supported the Colorados for different reasons: Flores had helped President Mitre defeat his rival, General Urquiza, in 1852; and the Brazilians had been repeatedly offended by the Blanco government, which they suspected of fomenting rebellion in the Rio Grande region. In short, transnational *caudillo* politics confounded the development of nationalism and independent foreign policies. It also provoked wars against governments that meddled in the internal politics of neighbors.

As the Uruguayan political conflict intensified in 1864, the Paraguayan dictator, Carlos Solano López, offered to mediate but clearly favored the Blanco

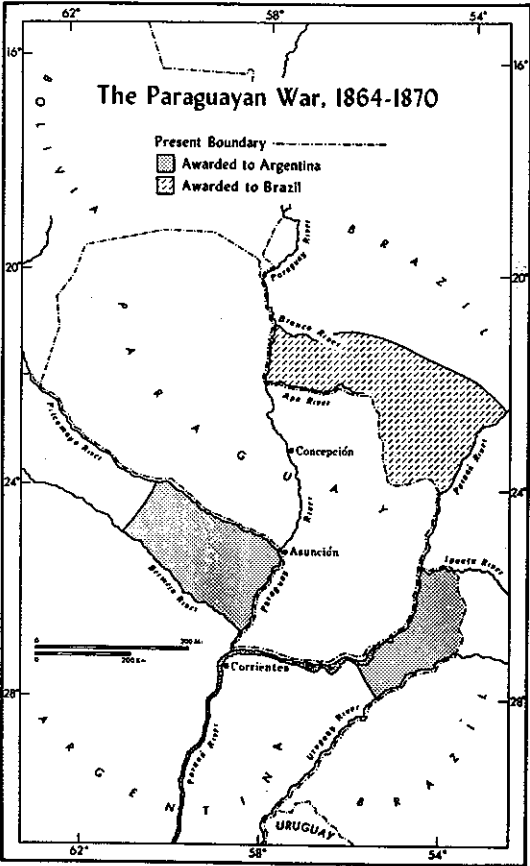
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Map 2-3. The Paraguayan War, 1864-1870. From Cathryn L. Lombardi and John V. Lombardi, with Lynn Stoner, *Latin American History, A Teaching Atlas*, published for the Conference on Latin American History by the University of Wisconsin Press, 1983, p. 59. Reprinted by permission of the University of Wisconsin Press

ously declared war on Argentina. On May 1, 1865, Argentina entered into a secret treaty (the Triple Alliance) with Brazil and the Flores government in Uruguay. Initially, Mitre was given command of the alliance's land forces; eventually, Brazil's armies bore the brunt of the fighting.

The war lasted five years, in part due to the allies' lack of military preparedness and professionalism, Argentina's continued internal strife, and the war of positions permitted by the terrain to Solano López. Fortifications on the region's rivers gave the Paraguayans a great advantage and required amphibious operations that made costly the eventual victory. The Brazilian Navy, the largest in South America in the 1860s, destroyed Paraguay's tiny fleet at the war's only important naval battle, at Riachuelo on June 11, 1865. From that time, the Paraná River served Brazil as a main supply line for its troops and allowed Argentine agricultural, livestock, and artisan industries to prosper as purveyors of Army necessities.

Argentina could never deploy more than half its army to Paraguay. Indian wars and internal rebellions (by one estimate, 117 uprisings of one sort or

party. He also desired to reaffirm Paraguay's territorial claims against Brazil and Argentina and, most of all, had an overblown notion that he could be the Napoleon of South America. Though unprofessional and poorly equipped, Paraguay had the largest army in the region. Brazil invaded Uruguay in the same year; Paraguay responded by capturing a Brazilian merchant ship on the Paraguay River and by invading Matto Grosso with 3,000 soldiers. Besieged and blockaded, Montevideo fell to the Brazilians in February 1865. General Flores was made provisional governor, supported by the occupation army.

Both Brazil and Paraguay then requested permission to transit Argentine territory to pursue the war. President Mitre rejected both requests, seeking to keep Argentina out of the war. Solano López ignored the directive and sent troops across Corrientes, massing forces south of the Paraná River. Paraguay seized several small armed Argentine vessels, having previ-

another from 1862 to June 1868) caused more casualties than Argentina suffered in Paraguay to mid-1868. Uruguay's General Flores led 1,500 men into Paraguay. Having taken heavy casualties in early battles, the Uruguayan army's presence faded. Indeed, after 1866 it was virtually nonexistent. (Flores was assassinated in Montevideo in February 1868.)

The allies' lack of effective joint commands and military coordination, periodic shortages of food and supplies, the terrible medical corps deployed on all sides, yellow fever, cholera, and more than occasional mutinies among Argentine and Brazilian troops also delayed the war's end. Finally, Brazil's Marshal Luís Caxias occupied Asunción and declared victory in 1869. There remained only the operative conclusion: the wounded, disheveled Paraguayan dictator lanced to death at Cerro Corá in March 1870, reputedly leaving as his last words, "I die with my *patria*" (or, by some accounts, "I die for my *patria*").

Paraguay was not dead, but it was horribly mutilated. It had lost half of its prewar population of 400,000. A major problem in Asunción was finding enough wagons to remove bodies for burial. Brazil maintained an army in Paraguay until 1876; a republican constitution (1870), the country's first, was inspired by Brazilian and Argentine "suggestions." Brazilian and Argentine meddling on behalf of one or another Paraguayan faction continued into the twentieth century.<sup>38</sup> Despite these calamities, the war reinforced Paraguay's nationalistic pride, glorified its military heroes, and set the country apart from its neighbors. In this sense, it confirmed nationhood, a *patria* for which Solano López claimed to have given his life. For thirty-five years after the war, with brief interludes, military officers controlled the presidency. Heroes of the war, these officers formed a faction of the Colorado party that dominated Paraguay into the 1990s.

In Argentina the war exacerbated internal strife, but eventually it gave the republic most of the disputed territory held by Paraguay and contributed to the consolidation of the Argentine Republic as a nation. Mitre lamented: "If half of Corrientes had not betrayed the national cause, arming itself to support the enemy; if Entre Ríos had not twice rebelled; if almost all the contingents had not rebelled at the time of fulfilling their duty, who can doubt that the war would have concluded sooner?"<sup>39</sup> Argentina spent half as much again on suppressing internal enemies—the die-hard federalists and *caudillos*—as on the war against Paraguay. Internal strife also diverted over half the army. To combat internal resistance, Mitre ordered opposition newspapers closed and sent critics into exile. Less ferocious than Chile's Diego Portales, Mitre nevertheless used the war to dispose of internal political enemies. The eventual victory assisted Mitre's successor, Domingo Sarmiento, in strengthening the national (federal) government, much as had occurred in Santiago after Chile's defeat of the Peru-Bolivia Confederation.

Ironically, Mitre's rival, General Urquiza, had managed not only to keep himself out of the cross fire but also to accumulate great wealth from the war-time demand for meat, leather, and horses. Brazil's General Osorio purchased some thirty thousand horses from the Entre Ríos *caudillo*, keeping Urquiza's cavalry from turning on Mitre while further enriching the country's most important regional *caudillo*. Mitre's supporters also did well with war contracts. After Paraguay's defeat, the victorious army suppressed the remaining "great

*caudillos*" such as Ricardo López Jordán in Entre Ríos (who murdered Urquiza and his two sons in 1870).<sup>40</sup>

After 1870 the Argentine national (federal) army would gradually become the country's most important political resource, as an Argentine nation gradually replaced the conglomeration of *republiquetas* that had existed since the 1820s. The Paraguayan War had given new credence to the idea of "Argentina." Symbolic references to "such terms as 'the constitution,' 'national honor,' and 'the nation's dignity' had come to hold new meaning for the troops who had fought through the genuine international struggle with Paraguay."<sup>41</sup> A concern for military preparedness, modernization, and professionalization would also become evident from the obvious limitations of Argentina's armed forces in 1865.

In Uruguay the war left the Colorado party in power until midtwentieth century. International meddling in the country's internal politics had been the immediate cause of the war. Flores's assassination in 1868 had snuffed out the original personalist motives, ending the career of the *caudillo* supported by Argentina and Brazil at the war's commencement. But Brazilian and Argentine meddling in Uruguayan factional politics persisted well into the twentieth century.

The war assumed national geopolitical meaning for Brazil, Uruguay, Argentina, and Paraguay. In effect, the postcolonial dispute between Brazil and Buenos Aires (Argentina) over the *banda oriental* remained at a stalemate. Uruguay survived as an independent buffer between South America's two largest countries, with military presidents succeeding one another until the 1890s. Paraguay was prostrate, a politically feeble entity to be manipulated by pretenders to hegemony. The total dead of all the participating armies numbered "at least 350,000—a figure more than twice the population of Buenos Aires in 1864, and about equal both to the population of Uruguay and to the estimated population of Rio de Janeiro in that year."<sup>42</sup>

For Brazil the war had profound and long-term consequences. By war's end the army, led by professional white officers from the Escola Militar at Rio de Janeiro, had grown to over 50,000. Mobilization of a large, predominantly black and mulatto army made the slavery question (Brazil still had almost two million slaves in 1870) more pressing and called attention to the country's archaic social and political system. Slaves earned their freedom for wartime service, and some provinces offered veterans monetary bonuses and land grants. In the northeast, veterans bought small farmsteads, but many veterans were cut loose from the army without significant pensions or rewards. Most refused to return to the status quo ante, although this meant joining the growing urban work force, becoming migrant workers, vagrants, or bandits. In 1871 the *Lei do Ventre Livre* (Law of the Free Womb) freed the children of slaves, thus anticipating abolition in 1888.

Before the war, the Brazilian military had received second-class treatment, despite its importance in suppressing regional rebellions and its key role in defeating Rosas, in alliance with Entre Ríos *caudillo* Urquiza, in 1852. During the war, Brazil acquired ironclad ships, modern artillery, and state-of-the-art repeating rifles from Europe and the United States. It also created an engineering corps that proved decisive in constructing an eleven-kilometer road through the Chaco that permitted Marshal Caxias to outflank Solano López in the Lomas

Valentinas campaign in 1868.<sup>43</sup> As in Europe and the United States, engineers and artillery officers were at the forefront of military modernization. Brazil's military victory over Paraguay raised the generals to national attention and created a new national pride in the army. A "new militant, independent social and political force had arisen within the empire."<sup>44</sup>

The war also "left its mark in a distrust of politicians who would declare war without providing adequate means or force to fight it with, and who would ignore and deprecate the victors, the wounded, the widowed, the orphans. Officers came to believe that only they were concerned about Brazil's defense."<sup>45</sup> As Argentina and Chile contracted for European missions in the 1880s and 1890s, Brazil's officers would take political matters into their own hands by overturning the monarchy and creating the Brazilian Republic (1889). Brazil's army would create a new *patria* and a new political order. Like their South American counterparts they would be the midwives of their nations and republican institutions.

For all the participants, the Paraguayan War meant an accelerated move toward national politics, a national army, and an expanded military influence in government. It also meant important socioeconomic, demographic, and political transformations. Political and diplomatic conflict had led to war, and war to political change and militarization of politics. Thus, the era of the *caudillos* was ending, and that of stronger Latin American nation-states and national armies was commencing.

### *The War of the Pacific, 1879-1884*

The last major nineteenth-century regional war once again engaged Chile against Peru and Bolivia. And, once again, *caudillo* politics in Bolivia and Peru complicated what seemed an international conflict. Like many of the nineteenth-century wars, the conflict between Chile, Peru, and Bolivia originated partly in unsettled boundary disputes. Its origins, however, did not significantly involve transnational support for *caudillos* and political factions. The War of the Pacific, more than any other nineteenth-century war in Latin America, was one of sovereign states (if not integrated nation-states) fighting over national security and economic interests.

Bolivia's weak presence in the coastal desert and Chile's development of nitrate, guano, and mineral enterprises between 23 and 25 degrees south set the stage for conflict from the 1840s to 1860s. In 1866, Mariano Melgarejo (1864-1871), the president and infamous *caudillo*, agreed on a treaty with Chile that fixed the northern Chilean boundary at 24 degrees south, with the proviso that Chileans and Bolivians could exploit mineral deposits in a sort of "joint sovereignty" in the disputed territory. The two countries would share the tax revenues. This treaty was as good as Melgarejo's word; when he was overthrown, his successors repudiated the bombastic drunkard's agreements. Negotiations reopened. In 1874 a new treaty reaffirmed the 24 degree-south boundary with Bolivia, dropped Chilean pretensions of joint sovereignty in the disputed territory, imposed a tax of ten centavos per metric quintal (100 kg.) on nitrate shipments to Bolivia's benefit, and prohibited Bolivia from increasing this tax for twenty-five years.



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economy measure, the Chilean government had to hire foreigners to man its miniature armada.

Peruvian and Bolivian forces, although they greatly outnumbered the Chileans, suffered from the effects of over a half-century of *caudillismo* and internal strife. Peru, like Chile, had a small fleet, largely manned by foreigners, described by contemporaries as "the offscouring of the foreign merchant and naval services." Peru's army, and even more so Bolivia's, was not equipped to fight a modern war. Moreover, Bolivia faced immense geographical barriers in deploying troops to the Pacific coast, one of the reasons that this territory had been settled and developed mostly by Chileans. Following a series of naval skirmishes, Chile controlled the sea-lanes while its armies, augmented by forced drafts of peasants, miners, and urban riffraff, occupied most of the Bolivian desert. When Chile occupied Pisagua and Iquique, political disorders ousted the presidents in both Peru and Bolivia.



Figure 2-1. Chilean troops kill Peruvian wounded during the War of the Pacific. *El repase* by Ramón Muñiz (1888). Original in the Museo Histórico Militar del Perú, Callao

After U.S. and British mediators failed to settle the conflict, Chile sent an army of 25,000 to Lima, crushed Peruvian defenders in mid-January 1881, and occupied the capital. The war was essentially won, but no official peace was achieved for two more years. Chileans looted Lima and took literary, art, and other treasures back to Santiago, thus ensuring more than a century of bitter recollections and demands for revenge. Peruvian guerrillas resisted in the Andean sierra into 1883, but the Chileans levied taxes on the local population to support their occupation army, imposed new port duties in Callao, and encouraged increased nitrate production in the conquered territories.



Figure 2-2. Andrés Cáceres, Peruvian military hero in the War of the Pacific and leader of guerrilla resistance against the Chilean occupation.



Figure 2-3. Chilean Colonel Alejandro Gorostiaga. According to Peruvians, he was "a miserable bastard" who ordered prisoners executed on their knees and shot in the back in the Battle of Huamachuco during the War of the Pacific. Rubén Vargas Ugarte, a Peruvian historian, says of Gorostiaga: "There are crimes that time doesn't erase and that can't be forgotten." Original in the Archivo Courret, Lima

Chile imposed harsh terms on Peru in the Treaty of Ancón (October 1883), signed by a Peruvian president approved by Chile. The loser country ceded Tarapacá province and accepted a ten-year Chilean administration of Tacna and Arica, to be followed by a plebiscite to decide the ultimate fate of these provinces. No plebiscite was ever held. Bolivia agreed to an armistice in March 1884, but no peace treaty was signed for twenty years. That nine of the fourteen articles in the treaty referred to guano and nitrates justified the conflict's nickname: "the Fertilizer War."

The War of the Pacific enlarged Chilean territory by more than one-third, stimulated agricultural, industrial, and shipping activity, and pulled the country out of the prewar economic stagnation that had threatened its political stability. More factories were founded from 1880 to 1889 than had existed in Chile beforehand. The war added leaders such as General Manuel Baquedano and Captain Arturo Prat to the pantheon of military heroes and reinforced the prevailing belief in the nation's racial and cultural superiority over Bolivia and Peru. Rapid victory also made available a large army of over 40,000, armed with repeating rifles and capable of subjugating the native people of Araucanía. Simultaneous campaigns by Argentine troops and completion of the southern railway integrated the southern frontier into the Chilean nation.

The defeat of the Araucanians ended the most important pre-1879 rationale for a standing army. The Indian frontier had provided a genuine military mission since independence. Acquisition of the nitrate territory and lingering border disputes with Argentina gave the post-war military a new mission. Threat of Peruvian and Bolivian revanchism made military preparedness and professionalization urgent. In 1885, Chile contracted